Building a Coaching-Management Platform for the Arab Market

The clearest gap in the Arab market is not consumer fitness apps — those are crowded. The gap is a back-office tool for the freelance coach: clients, subscriptions and collections in one place instead of WhatsApp and Excel.

This is the English version of the deep dive. The Arabic tab is the original.

The opportunity

The Arab market has three kinds of product, and none of them serves the freelance coach as a business. That is where the gap sits.

Category	Examples	Who it serves	What's missing
Consumer content apps (B2C)	ElCoach, AlCoach.com, Gymmawy	The end trainee	No coach dashboard, no subscriptions, no collections, no roster management
Gym and academy management systems	Fekra ERP, ALGYM, Gym Organizer	Gym or academy owners	Built around branches, QR gates and staff — far too heavy for a solo coach
Global coaching platforms	Trainerize, TrueCoach, My PT Hub, Kahunas	The freelance coach	English only, USD payments via Stripe, no Egyptian wallets, no local food data

Three gaps make the global products unusable in Egypt:

1. **Payments.** Trainerize, TrueCoach and Kahunas all run on Stripe or PayPal. The Egyptian coach collects via InstaPay, Vodafone Cash and bank transfer, and most clients don't hold an international card.
2. **Language.** Both Kahunas and FitBudd are English-only across coach and client interfaces — and the average Egyptian client won't use a fully English app.

3. **Food.** Every nutrition database is American. No koshari, no foul, no baladi bread, no Egyptian-seasoned grilled chicken with their macros.

Market size supports the idea without making it enormous: Egypt's fitness services market is projected to reach USD 0.52 billion at a 17.48% CAGR, and the global online coaching software market is heading from USD 3.7 billion toward USD 10.4 billion by 2034. The telling number: 86% of six-figure coaches train clients online — the shift online isn't a trend, it's where the money went.

One signal worth noting: ElCoach was founded in Cairo in 2019 and raised a seed round from Google for Startups Accelerator, 500 MENA and Endure Capital. Investors see the market — but they bet on a B2C model, not B2B for coaches.

Target user

Start with one segment only: the online coach with 10 to 50 clients running his business on WhatsApp and Excel. That's where the pain is highest and the alternative is worst.

Segment	Clients	What they use today	Core pain	Monthly willingness to pay
Beginner coach	1 – 10	WhatsApp + Google Sheets + PDFs	No real pain yet, manual still works	EGP 0 – 300
Working coach (the target)	10 – 50	WhatsApp + Excel + InstaPay transfers	Forgotten renewals, payment tracking, sending the same program 30 times	EGP 500 – 1,500
Influencer coach	50 – 300	A foreign platform or a team of assistants	Pays in USD and struggles to collect from Egyptian clients	EGP 1,500 – 5,000
Small studio or coach team	50 – 200	A local gym system or paper	Permissions and commission splits between coaches	EGP 3,000+

The coach's current day

This is the flow the product replaces, and every step is a leak point:

1. A new client messages him on Instagram DM or WhatsApp.
2. The coach sends pricing as an image or a voice note, and they agree on a one- or three-month package.
3. The client transfers via InstaPay or Vodafone Cash and sends a screenshot.
4. The coach logs the name and date in a spreadsheet or in his phone's notes.
5. He sends a questionnaire (Google Form) for measurements, medical history and injuries.
6. He builds a training program in Excel or Word, a meal plan in a separate file, and sends both as PDFs.
7. Weekly check-in: the client sends photos and weights over WhatsApp, the coach replies with a voice note.
8. At month end the coach remembers — or forgets — who needs to renew.

The losses the coach actually feels

- **Lost renewals.** No alert before a subscription ends, so clients slip through and the coach finds out two weeks later.
- **Repeated work.** The same "beginner fat loss" program gets rewritten from scratch for every client.
- **WhatsApp chaos.** Forty open chats, measurement photos buried in the scroll, and no way to see who went quiet a week ago.
- **Zero business memory.** Ask him what he earned last month and he can't say without sitting down to add it up.

The moment a coach says "I need something" is at 15 to 20 clients. Below that WhatsApp still works; above 50 he's either settled into a system or hired an assistant. Target the 15-client moment.

Features

The MVP has to solve one problem well: the coach knows who is subscribed, until when, and who paid what. Everything else waits.

Feature	MVP	V2	Defer	Why
Client database (profile, goals, injuries, measurements)	✅			The heart of the product
Subscription management (start, end, freeze, renew)	✅			Pain number one
Expiry alerts (to coach and client)	✅			This is what actually recovers revenue
Manual payment logging + receipt	✅			Before touching a payment gateway
Program builder + reusable templates	✅			Saves the most coach time
Client app (web first) to view and log workouts	✅			Web is faster and cheaper than two stores
In-platform chat		✅		WhatsApp beats you at this — integrate, don't compete
Nutrition plans + Egyptian food database		✅		Heavy data work, not a day-one requirement
Integrated online collection (Paymob/Fawry)		✅		Needs licensing and a compliance flow
Coach revenue dashboard and reports		✅		This is what keeps coaches subscribed
Native mobile app (iOS/Android)			⏸️	After you prove people pay
Per-coach white-label			⏸️	High price tier, not the MVP
AI program generation			⏸️	Every competitor does it; it isn't the edge
Coach teams, permissions, commissions			⏸️	A different segment entirely

The features that set you apart

Three things no global competitor does, each relatively cheap and immediately visible:

1. **WhatsApp as a channel, not a competitor.** Renewal alerts, session reminders, weekly measurement requests — all delivered to the client's WhatsApp via the Business API. This solves the fact that the Egyptian client won't open your app daily.
2. **Collection the Egyptian way.** The coach sends a payment link, the client pays by InstaPay, wallet or card, and the system logs it and renews automatically. This is what breaks Stripe's hold.
3. **A fully Arabic right-to-left interface.** Not a translation — designed RTL from the start, with Egyptian colloquial copy.

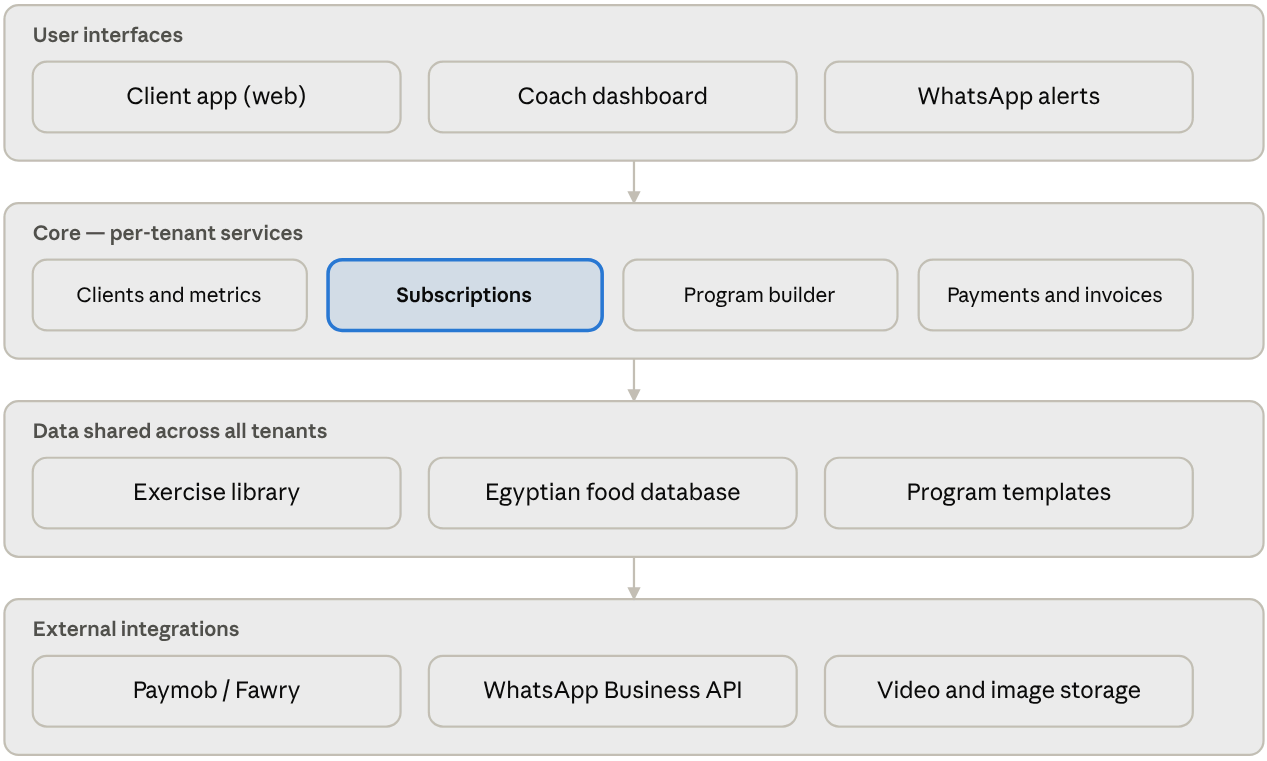
The hard call in the MVP

Don't build a mobile app first. Build a web app that works on mobile (PWA) for both coach and client. Reason: store apps eat three extra months plus fees (USD 99/year for Apple and USD 25 once for Google) and drag you into review cycles — while you still don't know whether anyone will pay.

Architecture

This isn't one app — it's one platform where each coach is an isolated tenant with their own data, clients and brand.

One platform, an isolated tenant per coach



platform architecture · 4 layers

Data splits in two: per-coach data (their clients, subscriptions, programs, revenue) that nobody else can see, and shared data (exercise library, food database, templates) that everyone reads from and each coach can extend with their own additions.

Technical decisions to make early

Decision	Recommended choice	Why
Data isolation	One database + `tenant_id` on every table + Row-Level Security	Cheaper and faster than a database per coach, and sufficient up to thousands of coaches
Interface	Arabic RTL web app (PWA) first	Saves three months and store fees until you're sure people pay

Decision	Recommended choice	Why
Identity	Coach account = tenant owner; client account = an invite inside one tenant	A client may later work with several coaches — design the relationship many-to-many from day one
Notifications	WhatsApp primary, email fallback	Nobody in Egypt opens email
Media	Exercise videos on a shared CDN; client progress photos on separate encrypted storage	Measurement photos are highly sensitive data — don't put them in the same bucket
Branding	A subdomain per coach (`coachname.yourapp.com`) plus logo and colors	The cheapest form of white-label, and it delivers the feeling of ownership

Three levels of white-label

Most global platforms sell the third level expensively. Start with the first:

1. **Branding inside your app** — the coach's logo and colors within the app, while the app carries your name. Free and simple.
2. **A dedicated subdomain** — `ahmed.yourapp.com`, or the coach's own domain. A higher tier.
3. **A standalone store app under the coach's name** — Kahunas sells this at USD 99/month plus USD 99/year for the Apple account, and FitBudd at USD 149/month plus a USD 75 setup fee. This level brings the most revenue and the most operational pain — defer it to year two.

One thing to know about full white-label

FitBudd requires the coach to have a D-U-N-S number and to pay developer account fees of USD 99 for Apple and USD 25 for Google. So the third level isn't just engineering — it's admin work and store reviews for each individual coach. If you build it, price it high enough to cover your time.

Money and payments

There are two completely different payment flows in the product, and conflating them is the biggest mistake available.

First: the coach pays you — a monthly platform subscription. Easy: card or wallet through one gateway.

Second: the client pays the coach — this is where the work, the licensing, and a real revenue share live.

Payment gateways in Egypt

Gateway	Fees	Recurring billing	Payment methods	Note
Paymob	Negotiated	✅ Officially supported with plans, intervals and retries	Cards, Meeza, mobile wallets, Valu, Apple/Google Pay	Most mature technically, clearest docs
Fawry	2.75% + EGP 3	✅ Billing and subscriptions platform	Cards plus cash at Fawry outlets	Strongest if you want to accept cash
Kashier	Negotiated	✅ Invoicing and recurring payments	Cards, wallets	Smaller, but flexible with startups
Manual transfer (InstaPay / wallet)	Zero	❌	Anything	In the MVP: the coach logs the payment manually

Paymob settles only in local currencies (EGP, AED, SAR) — so expanding to the Gulf means separate accounts per country, or a global Merchant-of-Record gateway if you bill in USD.

The smart MVP call

Stay out of the coach-to-client payment loop on day one. Just record it.

Reason: the moment you hold money on someone else's behalf you become a financial intermediary, which opens the door to central bank licensing and compliance. In version one, let the coach collect however he likes while the platform logs the payment, issues a receipt and renews the subscription. Once the idea is proven, add integrated collection and take 2% to 3% on top of gateway fees.

The Apple rule that matters most

This clause will save you 30% of every pound, and most people get it wrong.

Guideline 3.1.3(d) states that an app enabling the purchase of real-time person-to-person services between two individuals — with fitness training named explicitly as an example — may use purchase methods other than in-app purchase. So the coach can collect from his clients outside Apple's system with no commission.

But there are two traps:

1. Asynchronous text-based services — the client leaves a message and the coach replies later — are treated by Apple as a digital service requiring IAP. If your product is essentially chat and written check-ins, it may be rejected.
2. One-to-few and one-to-many real-time services must use IAP. Group programs and classes fall outside the exemption.

And a third point: a free app acting as a standalone companion to a paid web-based tool needs no IAP, as long as there's no purchasing inside it at all. That's your safest path: no purchase button anywhere in the app, and subscriptions handled on the web.

Pricing

Don't copy global dollar pricing. The Egyptian coach earns in pounds, and USD 59/month (My PT Hub's price) is roughly EGP 2,800 — more than he earns from a whole client.

Pricing models and which suits you

Model	Who uses it	Pros	Cons
Flat regardless of client count	My PT Hub (USD 59 unlimited)	Clear; the coach grows without worry	You lose money on the large coach
Tiered by client count	Trainerize: USD 9 to USD 275 across 9 tiers	Revenue grows with the customer	Coaches hate it — your bill rises every time you succeed
Free plus upgrade	Trainerize (free for one client)	Wide front door	Slow to convert to revenue

Model	Who uses it	Pros	Cons
Percentage of collections	Nobody in this category does it	Perfectly aligned with the coach's interest	Needs integrated collection, which is V2

Recommended pricing

A genuine free tier to break the trial barrier, and one clear paid tier. Don't build nine tiers like Trainerize.

Plan	Monthly price	Clients	What's included
Free	EGP 0	Up to 5	All core features — so the beginner coach grows with you
Basic	EGP 399	Up to 30	WhatsApp alerts, templates, revenue reports
Pro	EGP 799	Unlimited	Subdomain, custom branding, data export
Annual	Two months free	—	Dramatically improves your cash flow

The logic behind EGP 399: if the coach charges EGP 800 to 1,500 per client monthly and has 20 clients, he earns around EGP 20,000. EGP 399 is 2% of his income — a number that gets paid without thinking. Anything above EGP 1,000 becomes a decision that needs persuading.

Two things to do

- **Offer annual payment at a steep discount from day one.** In an inflationary market, cash up front protects you, and the coach likes locking a fixed price for the year.
- **Don't set the free tier below 5 clients.** The coach with 3 clients today is the one with 30 a year from now, and you want him growing inside your product, not outside it.

Data to put inside

An empty platform is worthless. The coach opens it the first time, sees a blank page, and closes it. Pre-loaded data is what makes him continue.

1. The exercise library

This is the most important asset you build and the clearest differentiator between platforms. For comparison: FitBudd has over 4,000 exercises and Kahunas over 1,000, and AICoach.com has over 1,300 filmed exercises.

Don't start at 4,000. Start with 250 exercises covering 95% of what actually gets written into programs.

Each exercise needs: name in Arabic and English, primary and secondary muscle, required equipment, difficulty level, a 10-second video, and execution cues in three lines.

Where to get it:

- **wger** — an open-source exercise database under a permissive license, with an API. Fastest start.
- **ExerciseDB / Free Exercise DB** — open GitHub databases with thousands of exercises and GIFs.
- **Film it yourself** — one shoot day at a gym with a decent phone camera covers 150 exercises. More expensive, but it's yours and it gives you a distinct look.
- **Don't take from competitors.** Trainerize and FitBudd videos are copyrighted, and that creates legal problems once you grow.

2. The Egyptian food database

This is the real competitive edge no global player can replicate, and also the heaviest work. For comparison: AICoach.com has over 500 food products and Vitarix has 16,000 regional dishes.

Start with 300 Egyptian items with macros: koshari, foul, taameya, molokhia, mahshi, rice with vermicelli, baladi bread, grilled chicken, minced beef, qarish cheese, boiled eggs, dates — everything people actually eat.

Where to get it:

- USDA FoodData Central (free and open) for raw ingredients — then build composite dishes from them.
- Egyptian food composition tables from the National Nutrition Institute.
- Calculate composite dishes manually from their ingredients. That's two weeks of work for one organized person.

3. Ready-made templates

The cheapest data to produce and the highest immediate payoff. The coach opens the platform, finds 15 ready templates, and adapts one in five minutes instead of building from scratch.

Template type	Examples	Suggested count
Training programs	Beginner fat loss 3-day, intermediate bulk 4-day, full body for women, home program with no equipment	12 – 15
Forms	New client questionnaire, health and injury declaration, weekly measurement form	4 – 5
Canned messages	New client welcome, renewal reminder, re-engaging a quiet client, milestone congratulations	8 – 10
Subscription packages	One month, three months, six months, with prices the coach edits	3

4. Data you collect yourself from day one

This isn't data you load, it's data you build — and it's what becomes your moat in two years:

- Which exercises get used most in programs (so you can rank the library).
- Average client subscription length per coach (a benchmark you can sell as value).
- Renewal rate before and after alerts are enabled (your entire sales pitch in one number).
- Which template gets copied most (so you can build variants of it).

Hands-on

The most important thing to do this week: sign up for four platforms yourself, create a dummy coach and a dummy client, and walk the full flow from registration to sending a program. Two days of this teaches more than a month of reading.

Platform	Link	Free trial	Why this one	What to focus on
Trainerize	trainerize.com	Free Basic plan forever for one client plus a 30-day trial	The industry standard — this is what you'll be compared to	Onboarding flow, program builder, client app
TrueCoach	truecoach.co	Free trial	Highest user ratings (4.6–4.8)	Check-ins and accountability, how client progress is displayed
My PT Hub	mypthub.net	30-day free trial	Simplest pricing (flat unlimited) and closest to your model	Subscription and payment management, the marketplace
Kahunas	kahunas.io	Free trial	Cheapest full white-label	How the branded app is produced, and whether English-only is actually a barrier
FitBudd	fitbudd.com	Demo	The standalone store-app model	Setup flow, what they require from the coach

Questions to come away with answers to

Take notes on each platform against exactly these points — they're what you'll build your product from:

1. **How many steps from signup to first client?** Count them. The platform that takes 12 is your opening.
2. **How does it handle subscription expiry?** Is there an alert? How many days before? Does it go to the coach, the client, or both?
3. **What is the client experience like on mobile?** Open it on an actual phone, not a desktop.
4. **What personally annoys you while using it?** That frustration is your feature.
5. **Try paying with an Egyptian card.** See whether it goes through or gets declined. This is the single most important test you'll run.

Also: talk to real coaches

Don't build anything before sitting with 10 Egyptian coaches. Don't ask "would you use an app like this?" — everyone says yes. Ask:

- Show me how you manage your clients right now. (Have him open his phone in front of you.)
- The last client who didn't renew — why?
- How much do you charge and how many clients do you have?
- Have you tried something before and dropped it? Why?
- If something solved this, how much would you pay monthly? (Then ask him to actually put down a deposit.)

The last question is the only one that tells the truth. Anyone will say "I'd pay" — few will take out their wallet.

Risks and obstacles

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	How to handle it
Coaches won't leave WhatsApp	Very high	Fatal	Don't compete with WhatsApp — integrate. Alerts go to WhatsApp; the platform is the brain, not the chat
Low willingness to pay	High	Fatal	A genuine free tier, a price under EGP 500, and collect deposits before you build
No easy online collection	Medium	High	Start with manual logging; defer gateway integration
A global platform localizes to Arabic	Low	High	Kahunas and FitBudd are English-only today; your edge is food and payments, not translation
Large coaches build their own	Medium	Medium	Different segment — don't target them early
Media cost (exercise videos)	High	Medium	Use open-source databases first; film your own once you have revenue

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	How to handle it
Leak of health data or client photos	Low	Fatal	Encryption from day one, separate photo storage, and a clear Arabic privacy policy

The real trap: an inverted chicken-and-egg problem

This isn't a marketplace, so there's no two-sided bootstrapping problem — but there's a harder one: **the coach who most wants the product is least able to pay, and the coach who can pay already has a system.**

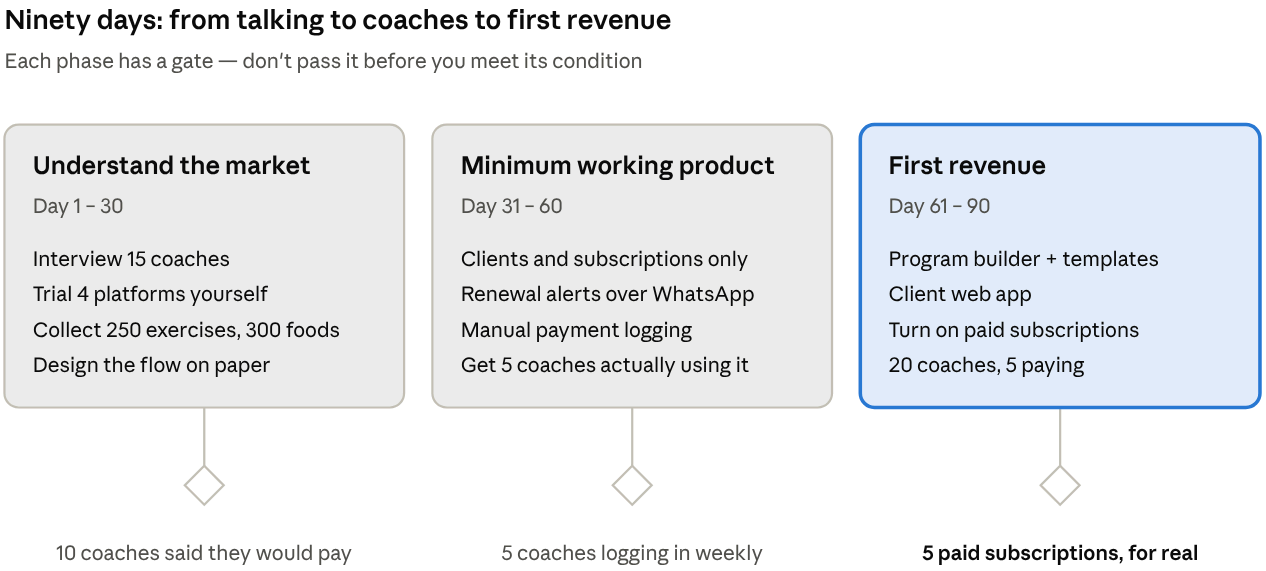
The only approach that works: target the coach during his transition from 10 to 25 clients. That's the moment he has enough money and hasn't yet settled on a system. Above it he's already habituated; below it he's still experimenting.

A hidden risk: seasonality

Egypt's fitness market is sharply seasonal. January, Ramadan and pre-summer are peaks; August and December are quiet. This will make your churn look terrible in certain months with nothing wrong in the product. Know this now so you don't panic in August and change the product for the wrong reason.

First 90 days

Don't start with code. The first 30 days are entirely conversations and product trials — not a single line.



90-day plan · 3 phases, 3 gates

The gates matter more than the phases. If you haven't met a gate's condition, don't pass it — go back and find out why.

Phase detail

Day 1 – 30: understand the market. The output of this phase is one document: the coach's current flow drawn step by step, with the points where money or time leaks marked on top of it. If you don't have that document, don't write code.

Day 31 – 60: minimum working product. Two features only: a client database and subscription management with alerts. No program builder, no nutrition, no chat. Show it to 5 of the 15 coaches you interviewed and get them using it on real clients.

Day 61 – 90: first revenue. Add the program builder, templates and the client app, and turn on paid subscriptions. The first 5 coaches get a free year in exchange for referring other coaches to you.

Three things not to do in these 90 days

- Don't build a native mobile app.
- Don't build AI that generates programs.
- Don't chase funding. Get 5 paying customers first; funding is 100 times easier afterwards.

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